



MOHIT BAGHEL HAS NOT MET HIS PARENTS IN A LONG TIME

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and she started acting in a series called *Rajkumar Aryan*," he says. He moved from Mulund to Kandivali to get closer to studios and channel offices and now accompanies his daughter on her city shoots and even outdoor schedules.

Avika has adjusted well to her daily schedule, which comprises four hours of shooting every day, but Shinjini Sengupta, who participated in the Bengali reality show *Dhoom Macha De* when she was 16, couldn't. Her parents encouraged her to participate, but Shinjini was unable to take criticism from the judges and fainted while performing. She slipped into depression, lost her power to speak and was paralysed. She has now sworn not to participate in reality shows ever.

The Absent Parent

WHEN LOVE IS AS IMPORTANT AS MONEY

It's an increasing urban phenomenon in a world where parents are busy

climbing the professional ladder. For them, the idea of parenting implies giving the best material pleasures to their children without always being able to provide for them emotionally. Shivani Malik (name changed), a 21-year-old Delhi University student, is a case in point. A bright girl with an aggregate of 94 per cent in Class XII, Malik has been failing for the last three years. Reason? "All my life I tried pushing myself to outdo others because I believed that if I was a good girl, my parents would take notice. When they were absent on the day I got an award for being the school topper, I knew nothing would change," she says. Now the most exciting thing in her life is the next party. Her mother has also given up on her, "We have given her the best education, always provided for her in the best ways. We gave up our best years to build a legacy for her, but what's the point," she complains.

Then there are others who are simply not present in their child's life. Like Mohit Baghel, 15, who came to Mumbai from Mathura two years ago to make it big on comedy reality shows *Chote Miyan* and *Chote Miyan Bade Miyan*. Baghel says his parents are supportive but can't accompany him to the city as they are busy with their work schedules. "I haven't met my parents in a long time as they are busy back home. I live in Mumbai with a local guardian," he says.

All parents think they know best for their child and they perhaps do. But when this feeling transforms into an obsession, it takes an ugly turn for the children. "Authoritarian parents decide everything about their child's life. This leaves no space for the child to grow and makes him aggressive," says Samir Parikh, psychiatrist and chief, Department of Mental Health, Max Healthcare. Perfect parenting is a combination of authority and effective communication. Most parents fail to master this mix. And more often than not, these children grow up with no sense of self. Or of the other, the parent. *with inputs from Natascha Shah, Krutika Kallury and Sumaiya Khan*

In the globalised world, parents have started to believe that being on stage is more important than being in the audience.

HARISH SHETTY, Psychiatrist

